University of St.Gallen

Course and Examination Fact Sheet: Autumn Semester 2025

7,037: Effective Data Communication - How to Talk about Data

ECTS credits: 3

Overview examination/s

(binding regulations see below)
decentral - Active participation, Analog, Individual work individual grade (10%)
Examination time: Term time
decentral - Presentation, Analog, Group work group grade (60%)
Examination time: Term time
decentral - Written work, Digital, Individual work individual grade (30%)
Examination time: Term time

Attached courses

Timetable -- Language -- Lecturer
7,037,1.00 Effective Data Communication - How to Talk about Data -- English -- Bünzli Fabienne

Course information

Course prerequisites

No special prerequisites. The course is assigned to the «Digital Channel & Customer Relationship Management» profile but can also be taken without selecting a specialization.

Learning objectives

- understand the fundamentals of data communication.
- be able to speak fluently, confidently, and clearly about data (even in ad hoc settings).
- be able to communicate competently about data in written form.
- be able to deliver compelling data presentations and pitches using data storytelling.
- be able to critically reflect on and challenge data-based insights.

Course content

Data have become a major game changer for businesses and start-ups. In the face of an increasingly fast-paced and complex world, data help identify business opportunities, predict customer preferences and behavior, evaluate newly launched products, and analyze employee performance. Amazon, Netflix, and Uber are only some examples of companies whose success is tightly tied to their ability to harness insights from data.

What does it take to leverage the full potential of data? One of the most powerful tools for making sense of data is a good conversation. It is through conversations that data-based findings are interpreted, challenged, put into a wider context, and made actionable. For data to be impactful, they must be part of our everyday discussions.

Yet in reality, such conversations often break down, spark confusion, or lead to misunderstandings. This commonly happens because people struggle to communicate about data in an appealing, accessible, clear, and easy-to-understand way. As a result, they may shy away from anything that has to do with data, feel uncomfortable in discussion with others, fail to critically question data-based findings, and experience anxiety when giving data presentations. Needless to say that failure to engage in meaningful data conversations comes with detrimental effects to organizational success. Consequences may range from overlooked growth opportunities to bad investments or misinterpreted customer needs.

Having insightful data conversations has become key to business success. This course will equip students with the skills required to design good data conversations. Students will acquire a skill called data fluency, which refers to the ability to talk competently, clearly, and critically about data with others by having grasped the key concepts of data communication and

knowing how to apply them in organizational settings. This entails learning how to critically reflect on and challenge data-based insights, (interactively) present and visualize data, deliver compelling pitches using data storytelling, and successfully handle disagreements about data.

Course structure and indications of the learning and teaching design

This course counts 3 credits. Accordingly, the total workload for students is 90 hours. This includes self-study, campus time and all examinations.

The structure of the contact study is planned as follows:

- One introductory session of 3 hours (kick-off seminar)
- Four sessions of each 4 hours consisting of group exercises, presentations, and discussion rounds. This also includes a guest lecture/on-site visit.
- One final session of 4 hours in which students will present their final group project

The structure of the self-study is intended as follows: 18 hours of preparation time for the lectures and 50 hours for the examinations (group presentation and individual paper).

The course is conducted in presence in St. Gallen.

Course literature

Eppler, Martin J., & Bünzli, F. (2022). How to Talk about Data. A Visual Guide to Data Fluency. Pearson.
https://www.amazon.de/How-Talk-About-Data-Fluency/dp/1292421193

Further readings will be communicated during the course.

Additional course information

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Examination information

Examination sub part/s

1. Examination sub part (1/3)

Examination modalities

Examination type	Active participation
Responsible for organisation	decentral
Examination form	Oral examination
Examination mode	Analog
Time of examination	Term time
Examination execution	Synchronous
Examination location	On Campus
Grading type	Individual work individual grade
Weighting	10%
Duration	--

Examination languages

Question language: English
Answer language: English

Remark
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Examination-aid rule
Free aids provision

Basically, students are free to choose aids. Any restrictions are defined by the faculty members in charge of the examination under supplementary aids.

Supplementary aids
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2. Examination sub part (2/3)

Examination modalities

Examination type	Presentation
Responsible for organisation	decentral
Examination form	Oral examination
Examination mode	Analog
Time of examination	Term time
Examination execution	Asynchronous
Examination location	On Campus
Grading type	Group work group grade
Weighting	60%
Duration	--

Examination languages
Question language: English
Answer language: English

Remark
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Examination-aid rule
Free aids provision

Basically, students are free to choose aids. Any restrictions are defined by the faculty members in charge of the examination under supplementary aids.

Supplementary aids
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3. Examination sub part (3/3)

Examination modalities

Examination type	Written work
Responsible for organisation	decentral
Examination form	Written work
Examination mode	Digital
Time of examination	Term time
Examination execution	Asynchronous
Examination location	Off Campus
Grading type	Individual work individual grade
Weighting	30%
Duration	--

Examination languages
Question language: English
Answer language: English

Remark
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Examination-aid rule
Free aids provision

Basically, students are free to choose aids. Any restrictions are defined by the faculty members in charge of the examination under supplementary aids.

Supplementary aids
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Examination content

Active participation (10%)

The active participation part of the examination will be evaluated based on the active engagement during the sessions and the engagement in the online forum.

Written paper *(individual) (30%)*

Students must submit a written report on the exercises done in class and the output created in these exercises (e.g., PowerPoint slides, videos, posters). The assignment calls students to present their output, explain the underlying ideas, and discuss the strengths and limitations of their approaches. Moreover, students are required to use and cite examples from practice to illustrate their arguments.

Students are expected to write in complete sentences, to develop their ideas with care, and to proofread their work. Poor presentation may result in loss of points. Late reports may be penalized.

Presentation *(in groups - all given the same grades) (60%)*

In this assignment, groups of students will be required to apply their newly acquired data communication skills to a real-life case. Specifically, they will need to choose a real business problem (e.g., company X has been continuously losing market shares for five years) and use the acquired data communication skills to pinpoint the cause of that problem and suggest solutions.

The groups will present their case to the class and answer questions from their peers and the lecturer. Teams can request a non-mandatory pre-presentation meeting. This meeting has no influence on the final grade. Presentation slides must be uploaded to Canvas one day before the presentation (PDF).

Timing: 15 min + 10 min Q&A + general discussion at the end.

Examination relevant literature

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Please note

Please note that only this fact sheet and the examination schedule published at the time of bidding are binding and takes precedence over other information, such as information on StudyNet (Canvas), on lecturers' websites and information in lectures etc.
Any references and links to third-party content within the fact sheet are only of a supplementary, informative nature and lie outside the area of responsibility of the University of St.Gallen.

Documents and materials are only relevant for central examinations if they are available by the end of the lecture period (CW51) at the latest. In the case of centrally organised mid-term examinations, the documents and materials up to CW 43 (Freitag, 24. October 2025) are relevant for testing.

Binding nature of the fact sheets:

- Course information as well as examination date (organised centrally/decentrally) and form of examination: from bidding start in CW 34 (Thursday, 21 August 2025);
- Examination information (supplementary aids, examination contents, examination literature) for decentralised examinations: in CW 42 (Monday, 13. October 2025);
- Examination information (supplementary aids, examination contents, examination literature) for centrally organised mid-term examinations: in CW 43 (Freitag, 24. October 2025);
- Examination information (regulations on aids, examination contents, examination literature) for centrally organised examinations: two weeks before ending with de-registration period in CW 45 (Monday, 03. November 2025).